The Adventures of Tom Sawyer

A simplified retelling

Original story by Mark Twain

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. A fence and an idea

Tom Sawyer lived with Aunt Polly in a small town beside the Mississippi River. She loved him and tried to keep him out of trouble. Tom usually preferred an adventure to a rule.

One Saturday, she made him whitewash a long fence. Other boys would be free to play while he worked. Tom considered his problem and found a different way to present it.

When Ben Rogers passed, Tom acted as though painting the fence were a rare pleasure requiring special skill. Ben wanted to try. Tom pretended to hesitate, then allowed him to exchange an apple for the opportunity.

Other boys followed. By the end, the fence was finished and Tom had collected a variety of small treasures. He had discovered how powerfully desire could be shaped by the suggestion that something was difficult to obtain.

At school and Sunday school, however, his shortcuts did not always work so neatly. An impressive appearance could last only until someone asked a question he could not answer.

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2. Becky and Huck

Tom became interested in Becky Thatcher, the new girl at school. He tried to impress her, and for a while they imagined themselves engaged. Then she discovered that he had made a similar promise to another girl. Their happiness quickly became a quarrel.

Tom’s friend Huckleberry Finn lived with far less supervision. Respectable adults disapproved of Huck, which made his freedom even more attractive to Tom.

One night, the boys went to the graveyard with a dead cat, following a childish belief about curing warts. There they witnessed something far more serious than they expected.

Three men were at a grave: Dr Robinson, Muff Potter and Joe, the man known in the town as Injun Joe. A fight broke out. Potter was struck unconscious, and Joe killed the doctor with Potter’s knife.

When Potter woke, Joe convinced him that he had committed the murder. Tom and Huck hid in terror. They swore not to tell, afraid that Joe would kill them too.

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3. Pirates on the river

Tom could not forget the murder. Seeing the harmless, troubled Potter under suspicion made his silence increasingly painful.

At the same time, difficulties with Becky and Aunt Polly made him imagine leaving ordinary life behind. He, Huck and Joe Harper ran away to an island to become pirates.

For a short time, it was wonderful. They fished, swam and had nobody telling them when to come home. But homesickness entered the adventure. Tom secretly returned to town and discovered that the families believed the boys had drowned.

Instead of immediately revealing himself, he arranged a dramatic return during their own memorial service. The astonishment was enormous. So was Aunt Polly’s relief.

Tom enjoyed the effect he had created, but he also saw the tears his disappearance had caused. An exciting story for the boys had been a terrible loss for the people waiting at home.

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4. Telling the truth

At school, Becky accidentally damaged the teacher’s book. Tom took the blame and accepted punishment to protect her. Their quarrel gave way to renewed affection.

Then Muff Potter’s trial began. The evidence seemed certain to condemn him. Tom watched a man face punishment for a crime he had not committed.

Fear had kept him quiet. It could not make the truth different.

He spoke to the lawyer and then testified in court. He described the graveyard and identified Joe as the killer. Joe escaped through a window before he could be caught.

Potter was freed. The town praised Tom, but public admiration did not protect him from fear at night. He knew that Joe was still somewhere beyond the lamplight.

Huck’s part in the secret remained less visible. The boys had shared the danger, but becoming a hero did not mean that either of them felt safe.

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5. Hidden money

Later, Tom and Huck went looking for buried treasure. In an abandoned house, they saw Joe and another man discover a box of coins. Joe was disguised, and the boys hid while he discussed moving the money to another hiding place.

Huck began watching for him. One night, he followed the men and learned that Joe planned to attack the Widow Douglas in revenge for something her husband had done.

Huck ran for help. A Welsh neighbour and his sons prevented the attack. Exhausted and frightened, Huck became ill and was cared for by the widow.

Meanwhile, Tom and Becky attended a picnic and entered a large cave with other children. As they explored, they moved away from the familiar paths. Their candles grew shorter, and they realised that they could not find the way out.

The treasure hunt had seemed dangerous enough. Now Tom faced a different responsibility: keeping hope alive for someone lost beside him.

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6. In the cave

Tom and Becky searched for a route back, conserving what little light they had. Hunger and exhaustion made each attempt harder. Becky grew weak, and Tom tried to reassure her even when he was frightened himself.

During one exploration, he saw Joe inside the cave. Tom withdrew before Joe could catch him. The place that might contain their way out also held the man he most feared.

At last, using a line to mark his path, Tom found a small opening that led outside. He brought Becky through it, and they were taken home.

The town celebrated. To prevent another disaster, Judge Thatcher had the cave entrance sealed. When Tom learned this, he told him that Joe was inside.

Men returned and opened the entrance, but Joe had died before they reached him. The danger was over in a way that left little room for the excitement Tom had once imagined around such adventures.

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7. Treasure and ordinary life

Tom realised that the cave might also hold the missing money. He and Huck entered by the opening Tom had found and located the treasure. The money was shared between them and placed under adult management.

Huck stayed with the Widow Douglas. She wanted him to attend school, wear proper clothes and follow household routines. To him, these comforts felt like restrictions, and he ran away.

Tom persuaded him to return by offering a place in a new band of pretend robbers. Huck could tolerate respectability more easily if it led to another imagined adventure.

The boys had become wealthy, but they were still boys. They could show courage and loyalty, then behave foolishly a little later. Growing up was not a single heroic moment. It was the longer work of recognising that other people’s lives continued beyond the stories they made for themselves.

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Words to keep

Whitewash — to cover a surface with a pale mixture used like paint. Tom had to whitewash the fence.

Supervision — watching and guiding someone’s activity. Huck lived with little supervision.

Testify — to give evidence in court. Tom agreed to testify for Potter.

Condemn — to judge someone guilty or sentence them to punishment. Potter was nearly condemned for another man’s crime.

Revenge — hurting someone in return for a wrong. Joe planned revenge against the widow.

Conserve — to use something carefully so it lasts. The children had to conserve their candlelight.

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A question to carry with you

When does Tom’s imagination help him, and when does it prevent him from recognising what other people are feeling?

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